

MAJOR LEAGUE PREVIEW— PHUTILE PHILS

Ed Sawyer Pessimistic

By TOM BRIERE, Valley Times Correspondent

CLEARWATER, Fla. (Special) — The Philadelphia Phillies, the National League's best bet for a last place finish, can tell their own springtime story. It goes like this:



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Eddie Sawyer, Philadelphia manager — "Pancho Herrera's big bat could help us if he comes through in the experiment at second base. Jim Coker, up from Buffalo, has to improve our catching." (No pennant predictions from the realistic Mr. Sawyer.)

Ken Silvestri, Philadelphia pitching coach — "One thing we've got is pitching. Not much to go with it, but Robin Roberts, Gene Conley, Jim Owens, Don Cardwell, Dick Farrell, Ruben Gomez, John Buzhardt, Curt Simmons and Taylor Phillips give us plenty of pitching."

Curt Simmons, former boy wonder southpaw trying to recover from a bone chip operation on his elbow at the age of 31 — "I don't throw as hard as I did once, but the control is better and I know more about pitching. I feel good this spring and hope I can help again."

Robin Roberts, now 33 and hoping to reverse a 15-17 record of 1959 — "I feel as strong as ever on the mound."

Joe Koppe, Phil shortstop — "It's better playing short up here than at Wichita in the American Association."

John Callison, rookie outfielder who came in a deal from the White Sox — "I haven't hit like I should. I've had a bad leg."

Ken Walters, at Fort Worth last year — "I'd sure like to stay up here." (He threw out two Card runners at second and home from right field and will soon have major league respect of his arm that he attained in the American Association for three years.)

Alvin Dark, veteran third baseman — "I'm still playing, not managing." (He's the dark-horse candidate for Sawyer's job when the inevitable mid-season switch is dictated by the Phils' lowly standing.)

Andy Cohen, former second baseman and now a Phil coach, has been delegated by manager Sawyer to make a second baseman out of Herrera.

Cohen stands 5-5; Herrera, a gigantic Cuban, goes 6-3 and 225 pounds and could become the largest second baseman in major league history.

The reason for the Herrera experiment is obvious in the International League batting accomplishments of this strong right-handed hitter at Buffalo in 1959. The erstwhile first baseman hit .329 with 37 homers and 128 runs batted in.

"He's remarkably agile for a big man," Cohen says. "He can field the position all right and makes the double-play pivot well. He's got to learn to get a better jump on the ball, going right and left. He's lost about 20 pounds and is working hard."

The Phillies already have a major league first baseman in Ed Bouchee and a long-standing problem at second base.

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